

YET ANOTHER YEAR OF 'WHAT-IF' FOR INDIA

India men's team head coach Igor Stimac has **warned** that it would take another four years for his team, ranked 18th in Asia, to breach the top 10.

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Every new year brings a fresh wave of optimism, regardless of the field of life. The world of football is no exception, and in 2024, we hope to see a rare, multi-club title race in the Premier League that could challenge Manchester City's dominance. In Germany, Bayer Leverkusen could pull off the impossible by ending Bayern Munich's stronghold over the Bundesliga title, which has lasted for the last 11 years. Similarly, in Spain, we could witness a fairytale run by Girona, which could culminate in it winning La Liga and upsetting the elite trio.

Meanwhile, Indian football fans may have to temper their expectations as the men's national team participates in the Asian Cup in Qatar in January. The team is likely to endure a group-stage exit, and coach Igor Stimac has already conceded that the tournament will be used to gauge India's performance for the 2026 FIFA World Cup qualifiers this year. If India progresses to the third

round, it will face Asia's top-ranked teams.

With Asia's quota doubled to 8.5 slots for the expanded World Cup, the qualifiers present India with an outside chance to make the showpiece event. Stimac, however, has warned that it would take another four years for India, ranked 18th in Asia, to breach the top 10.

In 2023, Stimac and his team showed a lot of promise, especially during their 2-2 draw against higher-ranked Iraq in the King's Cup. However, Stimac has been facing several challenges off the pitch while trying to steer the team. Although he received approval from the Sports Ministry to participate in the Asian Games despite not qualifying on merit, he struggled to find players to join the team until just three days before they were scheduled to leave for Hangzhou. During the tournament, the team barely made it through to the knockout stages and eventually got knocked out by an all U-24 Saudi Arabian team.

Additionally, Stimac's request for a longer training window before the Asian Cup was denied by the Indian Super League clubs. His proposed

solution of including Players of Indian Origin (PIO) did not gain any traction either.

The upcoming Asian Cup is the perfect opportunity to showcase his four-year efforts. Despite facing challenging teams in the group stage, a victory over Syria could increase India's chances of securing a spot in the knockout stage, at least as a third-place finisher.

In the realm of international football, 2024 promises significant events such as the African Cup of Nations, Copa America, and the European Championships. For Mohamed Salah, the AFCON stands as a chance to dispel the memories of the 2017 and 2021 editions and clinch his maiden international honour. France's incredible depth of talent, England's attacking riches, and Spain's technical brilliance make them favourites for the EURO title.

Until recently, Lionel Messi's crowning moment with Argentina appeared elusive, but now he starts the year as the reigning Copa America, World Cup, and Ballon d'Or winner. Messi's move to Major League Soccer gave a big fillip to American soccer, and now the States'